

AWARENESS PARADOX · THE ARCANA

The Major Arcana

A field guide to the 22 cards:
what to look for, what they mean, what to ask

@AWARENESSPARADOX

WELCOME

How to use this guide

A tarot deck has 78 cards. Twenty-two of them are the Major Arcana, the "greater secrets": the trump cards, numbered from 0, The Fool, to XXI, The World. They first appeared in Italian card games in the 1400s and were later read as a map of a human life.

This guide uses the Rider–Waite–Smith deck, published in London in 1909 and drawn by the artist Pamela Colman Smith. Almost every modern deck descends from her pictures, so the symbols here will help you read most cards you meet.

EACH PAGE GIVES YOU

The card and the symbols to look for · the upright and reversed meanings readers use · one question to ask yourself · one small thing to do today.

A SIMPLE DAILY PRACTICE

Each morning, shuffle the 22 cards and draw one. Read its page, ask its question, and do its small task. In the evening, write one line about what you noticed.

Tarot here is a mirror for reflection, read in the tradition's own terms. It is not a prediction, and no card is a sentence.

THE FOOL'S JOURNEY

One story in 22 cards

Many readers lay the Major Arcana out as a journey. The Fool, card 0, sets off, and the other 21 cards fall into three rows of seven, each a stage of the road.



0

The traveller



I



II



III



IV



V



VI



VII

I–VII · The outer world: skills, teachers, love, will



VIII



IX



X



XI



XII



XIII



XIV

VIII–XIV · The inner world: strength, solitude, change, balance



XV



XVI



XVII



XVIII



XIX



XX



XXI

XV–XXI · The great work: shadow, upheaval, light, wholeness

MAJOR ARCANA · 0

The Fool

> *The step before you know where the path goes.*

A young traveller walks toward a cliff edge with a small bundle on a stick, a white rose in one hand and a dog at his heels. The Fool carries the number zero, so readers place him before the journey or outside it, the part of us that is still willing to begin.



Rider-Waite-Smith, 1909 · public domain

LOOK FOR

- The cliff edge: the unknown, met with trust.
- The white rose: intention not yet complicated by experience.
- The dog: instinct, either a friend or a warning.
- The sun behind him: the day is only starting.

UPRIGHT

beginnings, trust, spontaneity, a leap of faith

REVERSED

recklessness, hesitation, naivety

ASK YOURSELF

What would I start today if I did not need to know how it ends?

TODAY

Do one small thing today that you have never done before.

MAJOR ARCANA · I

The Magician

> *As above, so below, in a single gesture.*

He raises a wand to the sky with one hand and points to the earth with the other. On his table lie the four tools of the suits: a cup, a sword, a wand and a coin. Readers see him as the moment you realise you already have what you need, and decide to use it.



Rider-Waite-Smith, 1909 · public domain

LOOK FOR

- The figure-eight above his head: the lemniscate, infinity.
- One hand up, one hand down: as above, so below.
- The four tools: water, air, fire and earth, ready on the table.
- Red roses and white lilies: desire and purity growing together.

UPRIGHT

willpower, skill, focus, resourcefulness

REVERSED

scattered energy, manipulation, talent left unused

ASK YOURSELF

Which tools are already on my table?

TODAY

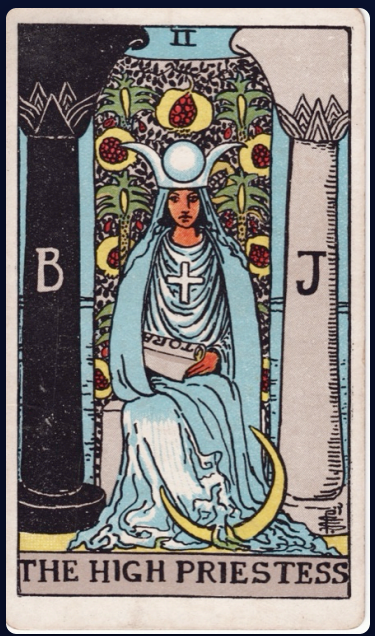
Name the four things you will use today, and begin with one of them.

MAJOR ARCANA · II

The High Priestess

> *She waits, and knows.*

She sits between two pillars, one black and one white, marked B and J for Boaz and Jachin, the pillars at the door of Solomon's Temple. Behind her hangs a veil of pomegranates. In her lap is a scroll marked TORA, half hidden by her robe. In the oldest French decks she was La Papesse, the female pope.



Rider-Waite-Smith, 1909 · public domain

LOOK FOR

- The pillars B and J: two opposites, with her seated between them.
- The veil of pomegranates: knowledge that is hidden, but close.
- The scroll marked TORA: the law, only partly shown.
- The crescent moon at her feet: intuition and the inner tides.

UPRIGHT

intuition, inner knowing, stillness, what is hidden

REVERSED

ignored intuition, secrets, disconnection from yourself

ASK YOURSELF

What do I already know that I have not admitted?

TODAY

Before your next decision, sit for one quiet minute first.

MAJOR ARCANA · III

The Empress

> *What is cared for, grows.*

She rests on cushions in a field of ripening wheat, with a forest and a waterfall behind her. Her heart-shaped shield bears the symbol of Venus and she wears a crown of twelve stars. Readers take her as abundance in every sense: creativity, the body, nature and nurture.



Rider-Waite-Smith, 1909 · public domain

LOOK FOR

- The wheat at her feet: a harvest that took a season to grow.
- The Venus symbol on her shield: love and beauty.
- The crown of twelve stars: the months, the zodiac, the cycle of the year.
- The waterfall: feeling that flows freely.

UPRIGHT

abundance, nurturing, creativity, the senses, nature

REVERSED

creative block, neglect of self, smothering

ASK YOURSELF

What am I growing, and am I feeding it?

TODAY

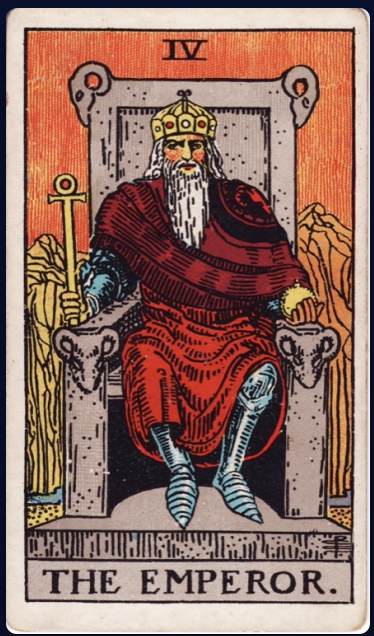
Spend time outside today, or make something with your hands.

MAJOR ARCANA · IV

The Emperor

> *Structure is a kind of shelter.*

He sits on a stone throne carved with four ram's heads, the sign of Aries, holding an ankh-topped sceptre and an orb. Under his red robe he wears armour, and behind him rise bare mountains. Readers see order, authority and the boundaries that let things grow safely.



Rider-Waite-Smith, 1909 · public domain

LOOK FOR

- The rams' heads: Aries, drive and leadership.
- The armour under the robe: readiness to protect.
- The orb and sceptre: rule over the world and over the self.
- The bare mountains: firm ground, built on rather than softened.

UPRIGHT

structure, stability, authority, healthy boundaries

REVERSED

rigidity, control, or a lack of discipline

ASK YOURSELF

Where would one clear rule set me free?

TODAY

Set one boundary or one routine today and keep it.

MAJOR ARCANA · V

The Hierophant

> *A key handed down.*

A religious teacher in a triple crown raises his hand in blessing over two kneeling students, with two crossed keys at his feet. Readers take him as tradition, teachers and institutions: the wisdom passed from one generation to the next, and the question of whether it still fits.



Rider-Waite-Smith, 1909 · public domain

LOOK FOR

- The crossed keys: the keys of heaven and earth, or of outer and inner teaching.
- The two students: learning that is received, then carried on.
- The raised fingers: a blessing, and a sign of what is shared.
- The pillars: the same doorway as the High Priestess, now open to the public.

UPRIGHT

tradition, teaching, mentors, belonging to a lineage

REVERSED

rebellion, questioning dogma, an unconventional path

ASK YOURSELF

Which teaching shaped me most, and do I still agree with it?

TODAY

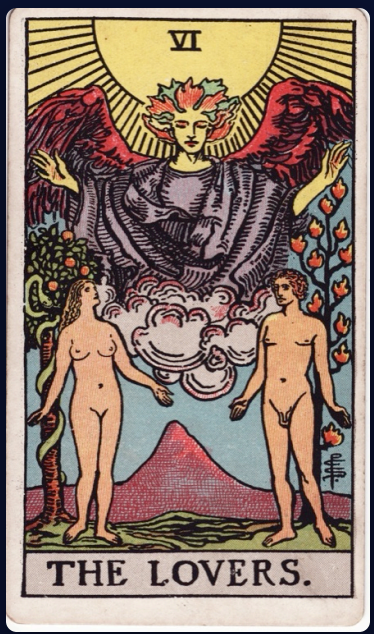
Learn one thing today from a tradition you respect.

MAJOR ARCANA · VI

The Lovers

> *A choice made by the heart and the head together.*

Under a winged angel and a blazing sun stand a man and a woman. Behind her grows a tree with a serpent; behind him, a tree of flames. Readers take the card as love and union, and just as often as a choice that has to match what you truly value.



Rider-Waite-Smith, 1909 · public domain

LOOK FOR

- The angel above: a higher view of the bond.
- The serpent's tree and the tree of flames: desire and spirit.
- The mountain between them: what the relationship can climb toward.
- The open hands: honesty, nothing hidden.

UPRIGHT

love, union, aligned values, an important choice

REVERSED

disharmony, imbalance, values pulling apart

ASK YOURSELF

Does this choice match what I value?

TODAY

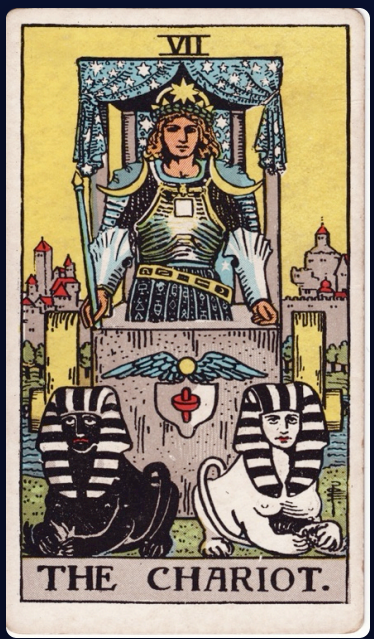
Write your three core values and test one decision against them.

MAJOR ARCANA · VII

The Chariot

> *Two forces, one direction.*

A charioteer stands under a canopy of stars, drawn by two sphinxes, one black and one white. He holds no reins. Readers see willpower and victory: holding opposing forces together by focus alone and moving forward.



Rider-Waite-Smith, 1909 · public domain

LOOK FOR

- The black and white sphinxes: opposing drives that must move together.
- No reins: control that comes from within.
- The starry canopy: guidance from above.
- The city behind him: the comfort he is leaving.

UPRIGHT

determination, willpower, direction, victory

REVERSED

lack of direction, aggression, being pulled two ways

ASK YOURSELF

Which two forces in me need to pull the same way?

TODAY

Choose one goal for this week and take one action toward it now.

MAJOR ARCANA · VIII

Strength

> *The gentlest hand closes the lion's mouth.*

A woman in white calmly holds a lion's jaws, with the infinity sign above her head and a garland of flowers around her. In the Rider-Waite deck Strength is card VIII; in older decks it is XI, and Waite swapped it with Justice. Readers take it as courage made of patience and compassion.



Rider-Waite-Smith, 1909 · public domain

LOOK FOR

- The lion: raw instinct and emotion.
- Her calm hands: mastery through gentleness rather than force.
- The infinity sign: the same as the Magician's, now turned inward.
- The garland: strength that is still soft.

UPRIGHT

courage, patience, compassion, quiet control

REVERSED

self-doubt, raw emotion, insecurity

ASK YOURSELF

What in me needs gentleness instead of force?

TODAY

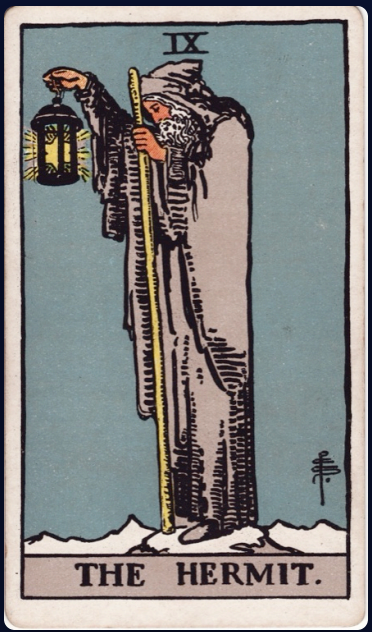
Meet one frustration today with patience, on purpose.

MAJOR ARCANA · IX

The Hermit

> *A small light, carried alone.*

An old man in a grey cloak stands on a snowy peak, holding up a lantern with a six-pointed star inside and leaning on a staff. Readers take the Hermit as solitude chosen for a reason: stepping back to find your own light, then holding it up for others.



Rider-Waite-Smith, 1909 · public domain

LOOK FOR

- The lantern and its star: inner wisdom, enough to light the next step.
- The snowy peak: a height reached alone.
- The staff: support earned on the climb.
- The grey cloak: modesty, the seeker who does not need to be seen.

UPRIGHT

introspection, solitude, inner guidance, wisdom

REVERSED

isolation, loneliness, withdrawal

ASK YOURSELF

What would I hear if it were quiet?

TODAY

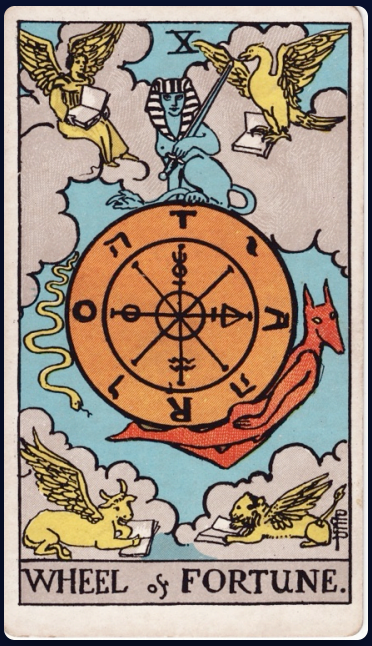
Spend twenty minutes alone today without a screen.

MAJOR ARCANA · X

Wheel of Fortune

> *Everything turns.*

A great wheel floats in the sky, inscribed with the letters T-A-R-O and the Hebrew name of God, with alchemical symbols on its spokes. A sphinx sits on top, a serpent descends on one side, and Anubis rises on the other. In the corners, four winged creatures read their books.



Rider-Waite-Smith, 1909 · public domain

LOOK FOR

- TARO, ROTA, TORA: the letters read as tarot, wheel and law.
- The serpent going down and Anubis coming up: every fall and every rise.
- The sphinx on top: wisdom that stays still while the wheel moves.
- The four creatures: angel, eagle, lion and bull, the fixed signs.

UPRIGHT

cycles, change, turning points, fortune

REVERSED

resisting change, a run of bad luck, breaking a cycle

ASK YOURSELF

Which cycle am I in, and which part of it?

TODAY

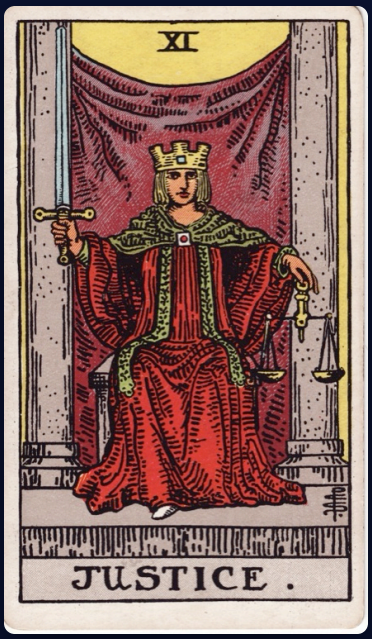
Notice one pattern that keeps repeating and write it down.

MAJOR ARCANA · XI

Justice

> *Every cause has its effect.*

A figure in red sits between two pillars, holding an upright sword in one hand and balanced scales in the other. One white shoe peeks out from under the robe. Readers take Justice as truth, fairness and accountability, the honest weighing of what was done.



Rider-Waite-Smith, 1909 · public domain

LOOK FOR

- The upright sword: clear decision, cutting both ways.
- The scales: everything weighed, nothing hidden.
- The shoe peeking out: justice is ready to act.
- The purple veil behind: compassion behind the law.

UPRIGHT

fairness, truth, cause and effect, accountability

REVERSED

unfairness, dishonesty, avoiding responsibility

ASK YOURSELF

Where do I owe the truth, to someone or to myself?

TODAY

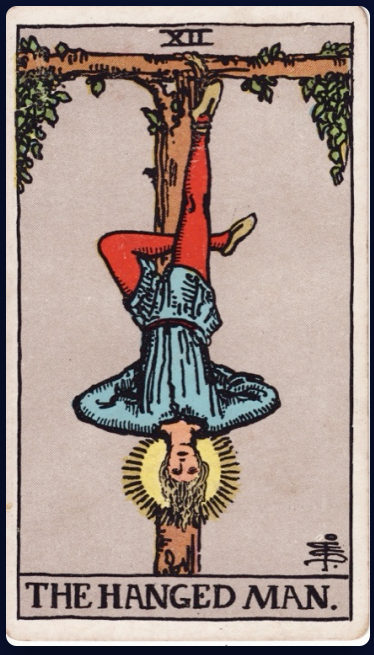
Settle one thing honestly today: an apology, a debt or a correction.

MAJOR ARCANA · XII

The Hanged Man

> *Turn it upside down and look again.*

A man hangs upside down by one foot from a living tree, his other leg bent to make a cross, a halo around his calm face. He is not suffering. Readers take him as the willing pause: surrender, waiting and the new view that only comes when you stop pushing.



Rider-Waite-Smith, 1909 · public domain

LOOK FOR

- Upside down: the world seen from a different angle.
- The calm face and halo: insight, not punishment.
- The crossed legs: the number four, stillness and foundation.
- The living tree: a pause that is still growing.

UPRIGHT

surrender, pause, perspective, letting go

REVERSED

stalling, resistance, indecision

ASK YOURSELF

What would I see if I turned this problem upside down?

TODAY

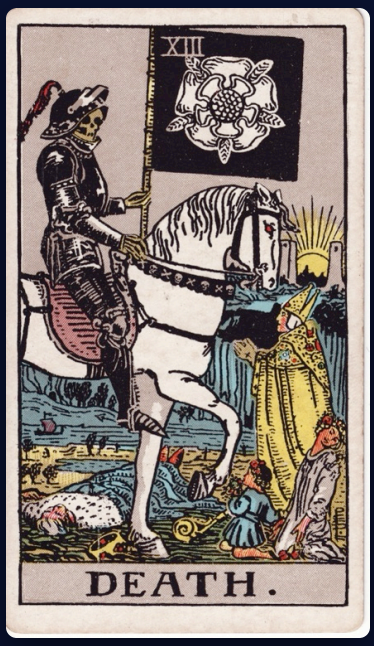
Argue the opposite of your opinion for two minutes.

MAJOR ARCANA · XIII

Death

> *An ending that makes room.*

A skeleton in black armour rides a white horse, carrying a black banner with a white rose. A king has fallen, a bishop prays, and a child looks up. Between two towers the sun is rising. Readers are clear that the card rarely means a literal death: it marks endings, transformation and clearing the way.



Rider-Waite-Smith, 1909 · public domain

LOOK FOR

- The white rose on the banner: life and purity carried through the ending.
- The fallen king: nothing is exempt from change.
- The sun rising between towers: what comes after.
- The river and the boat: a crossing, not a full stop.

UPRIGHT

endings, transformation, transition, release

REVERSED

resisting change, stagnation, fear of letting go

ASK YOURSELF

What is ending that I can let end?

TODAY

Clear one thing out today: a drawer, a commitment or a habit.

MAJOR ARCANA · XIV

Temperance

> *The right mix, poured slowly.*

A winged angel stands with one foot on land and one in water, pouring liquid between two cups. A path leads from the pool to a crown of light between the mountains. Readers take Temperance as balance and patience: blending opposites into something new, a little at a time.



Rider-Waite-Smith, 1909 · public domain

LOOK FOR

- Water flowing between the cups: alchemy, mixing and remixing.
- One foot on land, one in water: the practical and the emotional in balance.
- The triangle in the square on the robe: spirit inside matter.
- The path to the crown: a long, steady road.

UPRIGHT

balance, moderation, patience, blending

REVERSED

excess, imbalance, impatience

ASK YOURSELF

What needs a little less, and what needs a little more?

TODAY

Halve one habit today, rather than quitting or overdoing it.

MAJOR ARCANA · XV

The Devil

> *Look closely: the chains are loose.*

A horned figure squats on a pedestal above a naked man and woman who are chained to it. They have small horns and tails of their own. Look closely: the chains around their necks are loose enough to lift off. Readers take the Devil as attachment, compulsion and the shadow, and as the reminder that freedom is closer than it looks.



Rider-Waite-Smith, 1909 · public domain

LOOK FOR

- The loose chains: bonds we keep by choice.
- The inverted pentagram: matter placed above spirit.
- The small horns and tails: becoming what holds us.
- The torch pointed down: energy turned toward appetite.

UPRIGHT

attachment, compulsion, materialism, the shadow

REVERSED

release, breaking free, reclaiming your power

ASK YOURSELF

Which chain is looser than I think?

TODAY

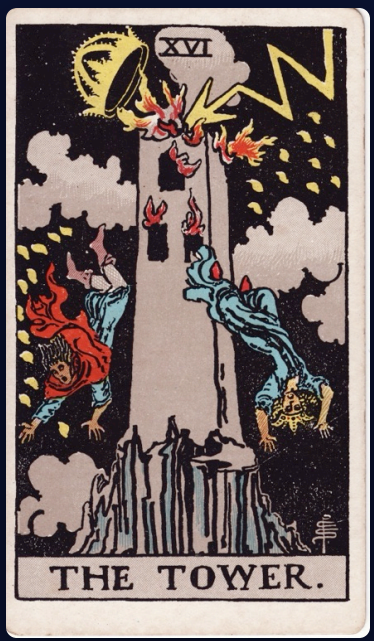
Skip one compulsive habit for a single day and notice the pull.

MAJOR ARCANA · XVI

The Tower

> *What was false falls first.*

Lightning strikes a tall tower on a peak, blowing off its crown. Flames pour from the windows and two figures fall. Readers take the Tower as sudden upheaval: the collapse of something built on a false foundation, and the clarity that arrives with it.



Rider-Waite-Smith, 1909 · public domain

LOOK FOR

- The lightning: a flash of truth.
- The crown blown off: pride and false certainty overturned.
- The falling figures: no one stays in the old structure.
- The flames: what remains is cleared for rebuilding.

UPRIGHT

upheaval, revelation, sudden change, awakening

REVERSED

avoiding disaster, fear of change, delaying the inevitable

ASK YOURSELF

What in my life was built on a false foundation?

TODAY

Name one truth you have been avoiding, out loud or on paper.

MAJOR ARCANA · XVII

The Star

> *After the storm, a clear sky.*

A naked woman kneels by a pool, pouring water from two jugs, one into the pool and one onto the land in five streams. Above her shine one great eight-pointed star and seven smaller ones, and a bird sits in a tree. Readers take the Star as hope and healing, the calm after the Tower.



Rider-Waite-Smith, 1909 · public domain

LOOK FOR

- Water onto land and into the pool: renewal for body and feeling.
- The great star: guidance and inspiration.
- Her nakedness: nothing left to hide.
- The bird in the tree: the soul, singing again.

UPRIGHT

hope, renewal, calm, inspiration

REVERSED

despair, disconnection, loss of faith

ASK YOURSELF

What gives me hope right now?

TODAY

Look at the night sky for five minutes tonight.

MAJOR ARCANA · XVIII

The Moon

> *Not everything at night is what it seems.*

A full moon with a sleeping face hangs between two towers. Below, a dog and a wolf howl, and a crayfish crawls out of a pool onto a winding path. Readers take the Moon as dreams, intuition and illusion: the uncertain ground where fear and insight both grow.



Rider-Waite-Smith, 1909 · public domain

LOOK FOR

- The dog and the wolf: the tame and the wild sides of us.
- The crayfish leaving the pool: something rising from the unconscious.
- The winding path: a way forward, even in half-light.
- The two towers: the gateway into the unknown.

UPRIGHT

intuition, dreams, the unconscious, uncertainty

REVERSED

clarity returning, fear released, confusion lifting

ASK YOURSELF

What am I afraid of that may not be real?

TODAY

Write down last night's dream, or one recurring worry.

MAJOR ARCANA · XIX

The Sun

> *Joy, in full daylight.*

A naked child rides a white horse in front of a wall of sunflowers, holding a red banner, under a radiant sun with a face. Readers take the Sun as the brightest card in the deck: joy, vitality, success and the simple clarity of a good day.



Rider-Waite-Smith, 1909 · public domain

LOOK FOR

- The child: innocence regained, after the whole journey.
- The sunflowers: everything turning toward the light.
- The white horse: strength that is now gentle.
- The red banner: life, carried openly.

UPRIGHT

joy, success, vitality, clarity

REVERSED

temporary sadness, blocked joy, overconfidence

ASK YOURSELF

What lights me up?

TODAY

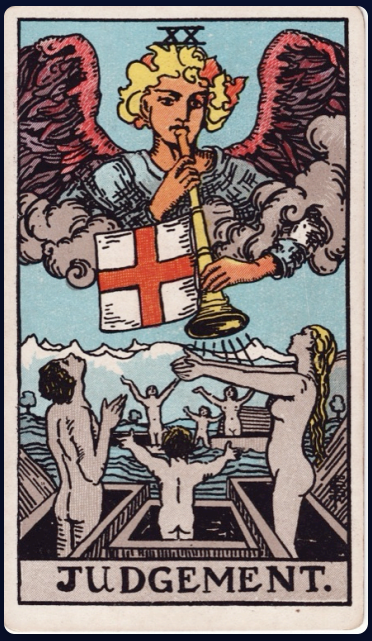
Get morning sunlight today, and do one thing purely for joy.

MAJOR ARCANA · XX

Judgement

> *Rise when you are called.*

An angel blows a trumpet hung with a cross banner, and below, people rise from their coffins with their arms open. Readers take Judgement as awakening: a reckoning with your past, an inner call, and the decision to answer it.



Rider-Waite-Smith, 1909 · public domain

LOOK FOR

- The trumpet: a call that cannot be ignored.
- The rising figures: rebirth, a second chance.
- The open arms: acceptance of what is being asked.
- The mountains: the heights still to come.

UPRIGHT

awakening, reckoning, calling, renewal

REVERSED

self-doubt, ignoring the call, harsh self-judgement

ASK YOURSELF

What am I being called to?

TODAY

Write the one-sentence version of your calling.

MAJOR ARCANA · XXI

The World

> *The circle closes, and opens again.*

A dancing figure holding two wands floats inside a laurel wreath tied with red ribbons. In the four corners are the same four creatures as on the Wheel of Fortune. Readers take the World as completion and wholeness: the end of one great cycle, and the Fool's next beginning.



Rider-Waite-Smith, 1909 · public domain

LOOK FOR

- The laurel wreath: victory and completion.
- The dancer: everything integrated, moving freely.
- The two wands: the Magician's single wand, now doubled.
- The four creatures: the whole world, balanced.

UPRIGHT

completion, integration, wholeness, accomplishment

REVERSED

something unfinished, seeking closure, delays

ASK YOURSELF

What have I finished that I have not celebrated?

TODAY

Mark the end of something today with a small ritual.

PRACTICE

A three-card reading

When you face a decision, shuffle the 22 cards, think of the question, and lay out three cards from left to right.

1	2	3
Where you stand	What is in the way	What would help

Read each card's page. Then read the three as one sentence: "I am in *(card 1)*, held back by *(card 2)*, and helped by *(card 3)*." Write that sentence down, and come back to it in a week.

A note on reversed cards

If a card lands upside down, some readers use the reversed meaning, and others read every card upright. Choose one way and keep to it.

MORE FROM AWARENESS PARADOX

Keep going

New reels every day on tarot, hermeticism, alchemy, meditation and the ancient world. Comment the keyword on any reel and the guide arrives in your messages.

- ARCANA · this guide, the 22 Major Arcana
- AZOTH · the Emerald Tablet and the seven Hermetic principles
- STILLNESS · seven evening practices from the ancient world
- SOLSTICE · the sacred-sky calendar for 2027
- MAAT · the 42 declarations of the Book of the Dead

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